

CAN PLANTS GROW ON MARS?

Humans may one day garden on Mars. The soil has the nutrients needed by plants, with toxins that could be removed. However, Mars has no liquid water, so this would need to be produced for the plants. The plants would also need protecting from harmful conditions.

Sort-of soil

Martian soil is very similar to moon dust. Neither contains living things to create spaces, which make soil suitable for plants.

The rover will drill down to look for microorganisms in the soil.

Martian rocks

Long ago it rained on Mars. The water froze in cracks on the rocky surface. The ice expanded and broke off tiny fragments of rock. These are still part of the soil today.

Mars's atmosphere is 95 per cent carbon dioxide (a gas plants need).